Walking Meditation

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION TEACHER CERTIFICATION PROGRAM

Script for Guided Meditation

For the able-bodied

One of the most useful and grounding ways of attending to our body and mind is the practice of walking meditation. Walking meditation is a simple and universal practice for developing calm, connectedness, and embodied awareness. It can be practiced regularly, before or after sitting meditation or anytime on its own, such as after a busy day at work or on a lazy Sunday morning. The art of walking meditation is to learn to be aware as you walk, to use the natural movement of walking to cultivate mindfulness and wakeful presence.

To practice, select a quiet place where you can walk comfortably back and forth, indoors or out, about a dozen to thirty paces in length. Begin by standing at one end of this "walking path," with your feet firmly planted on the ground. Let your hands rest easily, wherever they are comfortable. First, open your senses to see and feel the whole surroundings. After a minute of becoming mindful in this way, bring your attention back to focus on the body. Center yourself, and feel how your body is standing on the earth. Feel the pressure on the bottoms of your feet and the other natural sensations of standing. Let yourself be present and alert.

Begin to walk a bit more slowly than usual. Let yourself walk with a sense of ease and dignity. Relax and let your walking be easy and natural, as if you were a king or queen out for a royal stroll. Pay attention to your body. With each step, feel the sensations of lifting your foot and leg off of the earth. Then mindfully place your foot back down. Feel each step mindfully as you walk. If it's helpful, you can inwardly whisper to yourself "lifting" and "placing" with each step.

When you reach the end of your path, pause for a moment. Center yourself, carefully turn around, and pause again so that you can be aware of the first step as you walk back. You can experiment with the speed, walking at whatever pace keeps you most present. In walking back and forth, you naturally realize that you are "not trying to get somewhere"; you are learning to be present just where you are.

Continue to walk back and forth for ten or twenty minutes or longer. As with focusing on the breath in sitting, your attention will wander away many times. As soon as you notice this, acknowledge where it went softly: "wandering," "thinking," "hearing," "planning." Then return to feel the next step. Like training a puppy, you will need to come back a thousand times. Whether you have been away for one second or for ten minutes, no matter. Simply acknowledge where you have been and then come back to being alive here and now with the next step you take. If you feel you have lost connection with walking, you can always stand quietly, steady yourself in the present, and then begin walking again.

Use the walking meditation to calm and collect yourself and to live more wakefully in your body. Let it teach you how to stay centered and steady as the waves of experience rise and fall with each step. Practice at home first. You can then extend your mindful walking in an informal way when you go shopping, whenever you walk down the street, or walk to or from your car. You can learn to enjoy walking for its own sake instead of the usual planning and thinking and, in this simple way, begin to be truly present, to bring your body, heart, and mind together, wise and balanced, as you move through your life.